



How does it work?

Strong scientific evidence tells us that:

1. The heart is the most efficient muscle we have and it can adapt really well to changes in the demands we put on it.
2. With regular exercise, the muscles in your arms and legs can become more efficient allowing you to do more work or the same amount of work for less effort.
3. As you work towards a basic level of fitness, your heart will become better at supplying the energy you need to meet the demands of daily life – you will be able to do the same work for less effort.

With regular exercise, people with heart failure can better manage their condition and improve the amount of activity they can do. The aim of our exercise programme is to get your body (and mind) into good enough shape so that you can get some of the benefits above. It is amazing how much you can gain with each week of exercise.

In this manual, we offer a choice of exercise options to help you to build up and maintain your fitness and strength. The exercise programme lasts between 2 to 3 months and the longer you stick at it, the more you are likely to gain.

Your facilitators will help you with making decisions around what is best for you. The two options are:

1. **Our walking programme:** Walking is a great way to exercise. If you take this option it is important to keep track of your level of effort, so that you can gradually build your ability to exercise safely. The aim will be to gradually increase the number of steps you take and the time you spend walking. This option will suit you if you are happy to walk outside on your own, even if just for a short while.
2. **Our chair-based exercises:** The chair-based programme will guide you through a series of exercises that you can do in your own home. There are seven stages, each increasing in time and the amount of effort needed. How you progress will depend on how easy or hard you find each stage. This option also includes resistance exercise (using your body weight) which we know helps to maintain or in some cases improve muscle strength. This doesn't mean you have to lift heavy weights! Instead we steadily use more and more of your body weight during movements that you would routinely use in your daily life. Adding resistance in this way means that the benefits from your exercise carry over directly into your daily life.

As we will see later, you can combine sessions from both the chair-based and walking programme if you like.

Your walking programme

What you will need:

- a good pair of training shoes is best, but comfortable shoes or trainers, properly laced, will be fine
- comfortable clothing
- some ideas about where you can walk safely and easily and where you might enjoy walking
- a way of tracking your progress (see below)

Step 1: Getting started

Your facilitator should help you to get started and you should discuss ...

- How much to do. This should be recorded on your 'Exercise Record' in the Progress Tracker. At the start, your exercise goals will depend on your current fitness. A good indicator of this is how far you can walk in a certain time, or how long you can walk for without needing to rest.
- Where you are going to walk on a regular basis that is safe and that might be enjoyable or useful to you in some way. Starting with somewhere that is not too hilly is probably a good idea.
- **Warming up before you exercise – this means doing 3-5 minutes of slow walking indoors or outside. And you should do the same to cool down after.** Think of it like driving a car – if you keep starting your car in fourth gear, the engine won't last very long. It's the same with your heart – you need to start off gently and 'go up through the gears'.

- How to make sure that you are working at the right intensity to build up your fitness.
- How to keep track of your progress. This might involve recording the time you walked for or using a step-counter (called a pedometer). Keeping track of your progress over time can be very motivating.

The walking programme involves going out walking at least 3 times a week. Ideally, you should spread the activity across the week, allowing a rest day in between each session. Your starting point will be one of the following ...

LEVEL ONE:	5 to 10 minutes
LEVEL TWO:	10 to 15 minutes
LEVEL THREE:	20 minutes and above

These are the times that you should walk for in addition to the warm-up and cool down time.

Each session will consist of walking outdoors. Pick somewhere that you can get to and from easily. You should also try to pick a place where you might enjoy being and where it is easy to end the walk if any problems arise. For example, local parks, beauty spots or shopping centres, with plenty of benches. It may be worth considering what shortcuts there are back to home (or your transport home). Remember that wherever you walk to, you will need to be able to get back!

If you are uncomfortable with the idea of walking outdoors on your own, it might help to walk with a companion or to take a mobile phone with you and make sure that somebody knows you are out walking.

“You need to get a bit out of breath, but not so much that you can’t talk”

Remember, you should walk at a pace that makes you breathe heavier, feel warmer and have a slightly faster heartbeat. But you should still be able to talk. This means you are working at a ‘moderate intensity’ – you need to work at this level to build up your fitness. Always cool down after exercise as your heart needs to come gently back to a normal rate.

Step 2: Building up your walking fitness

You should stay at the same level until you feel ready to increase your walk time.

- *If you are struggling* to complete the walk or getting too exhausted, you may need to reduce your walking time and build up from a lower starting point. The important thing is to keep working at the right intensity (without over doing it).
- *If you found your last two or three walking sessions easy*, you are progressing and you should increase the length of time you walk for.
- If you want to increase your fitness further, you can add in some ‘faster walking’ sections to your walk. You can start with 2, 3 or 5 minutes of faster walking. Or you can set challenges based on getting from one landmark to another at a faster pace. Another way to increase the challenge is to change your route to make it more hilly.
- **Once you are doing 20 minutes three or four times a week (excluding warm-up and cool-down time), you will have achieved a basic**

level of fitness that is good for your heart and for your health in general – well done!

- This is a good basic level to maintain over time but if you feel able, you could build up to 30 minutes per session.
- You can replace any number of minutes of walking with other ‘moderately intense’ activities if you prefer.

It may have been a long time since you did any regular exercise. This isn’t a problem. Our experience tells us that no matter what level you start at, you can make progress. It’s all in your control and you can progress at your own pace. Your facilitator is also here to help!

You can use the Progress Tracker to record how long you walk for and how easy or hard each walk was. This will help you to see when it is time to increase your target. Over time, you may find that you need to walk faster to still be working at a moderate intensity (out of breath but able to talk) – that is normal and means that your fitness is increasing!

Depending on your age and your overall health you may not be able to get as far as 20 minutes per session. If that is the case, don’t worry – any increase in activity is good for you. The aim is to build up your fitness as much as is reasonably possible. Once you have reached a level that is as good as it can be, then the important thing is to keep it up!

If you are concerned that the amount of activity you are doing is too much, please discuss this with your facilitator, your GP or your heart failure nurse.

Monitor your progress

It can be helpful to keep track of your progress as this allows both you and your facilitator to see how your fitness is changing over time. There are many digital activity monitors (often called activity trackers) available. These include clip-on or wrist-worn pedometers and smartphone apps. There are also ways of monitoring your activity without digital trackers. It will help to choose a way of monitoring your activity that you are most comfortable with. You can monitor your progress by ...

- thinking about the amount of effort you are making – how easy or hard you are finding it
- keeping track of the amount of time you are walking for
- using a pedometer to count the number of steps you take
- you can also use a pedometer and a watch or a stopwatch to work out how many steps per minute you are doing (your walking pace) or measure distance over time instead of steps

These are all useful ways to see if your basic fitness is increasing and to see when you should move up a level. Your Progress Tracker allows you to record any or all of the things above and some digital trackers or mobile phones can automatically do this. You may find it useful to discuss your progress with your facilitator each time you meet. Your facilitator will be able to help you choose the right monitoring tool or show you how to monitor without a digital tracker.

What to do if you get very out of breath

It is normal for your breathing to get faster when you exercise and indeed it is important for you to work at a level which does increase your rate of breathing. However, if you work too hard you may find that your breathing gets too fast and you start to feel increasingly breathless. If you get to the point of being so out of breath that you can't speak, this is a sign that you are working too hard and should slow down.

At this point during your walk or exercise, you could **try using the 'active recovery' technique below to manage your breathing...**

- Monitor your breathing rate and slow down your activity as this will help you gain control of your breathing. Try to do this without stopping the exercise, but if your breathing doesn't settle, it is OK to stop!
- You should notice your breathing rate gradually slowing down and coming back to the right level – breathing hard but still able to speak.
- If this doesn't work then slow down further until your breathing comes back to a comfortable rate.
- The trick is to take action before you get so out of breath that you have to stop – by slowing down you are recovering while being active.

If at any point during exercise your breathlessness becomes distressing, then stop

*Your
energy for the week is like
having money in the bank. Don't
spend it all at once or you'll go
overdrawn!*

and concentrate on slowing your breathing to a normal rate. You can use the relaxation exercises in the 'Managing Stress' section later on in this manual.

Please note, increased breathlessness at rest, or with small amounts of exercise, may be related to fluid retention, if you are breathless and do not think it is due to exercising, please contact a health care professional.

Helpful hints

1. Plan your week and fit the walking into your everyday routine. You're more likely to stick to the plan if you have a routine, if the walk is enjoyable or if the walk helps you to do something you need or want to do regularly (like visiting a friend or relative, or going to the shops).
2. Have a back-up plan in case of bad weather. How else could you get 10, 15 or 20 minutes of moderate intensity activity? How about doing the chair based exercises? Or, going to a leisure centre or an exercise group. Your facilitator may be able to give you information on local exercise groups.
3. It is good to challenge yourself, but don't overdo it, as this can make you exhausted the next day. Bear in mind what other work or household jobs you need to do and plan accordingly.
4. As a general rule, try not to do things that make you so breathless you can't speak. If you get to this point, you should probably slow down a bit.
5. Vary your time, pace and course to challenge yourself and keep it interesting.
6. If you wish, you can combine sessions from the chair based exercises and the walking programme. You first need to set a starting point for the new programme (discuss this with your facilitator). Then it is very straightforward – any session of walking can be switched for a session of the chair based exercises (and you can switch 2 or all 3 sessions if you like).
7. If you have chest pains when exercising and your GP does not already know about this, you should stop exercising immediately. Contact your GP as soon as possible to discuss this and your facilitator.

If you have angina and you experience chest pain during exercise, stop exercising immediately. Take 1-2 puffs of your GTN (glycerine trinitrate) spray if that has been prescribed and wait for the pain to go away. Take a second dose after 5 minutes if you still have pain. Dial 999 if your pain is still not relieved after using your GTN spray twice, or if you experience unbearable chest pain at any time. If the pain goes away and you feel OK, you can carry on, but wait a few minutes and work within the limits of your angina.

8. If you have nausea, dizziness or palpitations (feeling your heart beating abnormally fast or irregularly) when exercising, stop immediately. If these symptoms don't go away, contact your GP as soon as possible.
9. If you have been prescribed a GTN spray, always carry it with you, especially during exercise.
10. If you have run out of your usual medications, or have forgotten to take them, do not exercise until this has been sorted out.
11. Talk to your facilitator or GP if you have any concerns.

Step 3: Keeping going

Walking is a great way to maintain or increase your basic fitness. Hopefully, after a few months of regular exercise, you will be feeling the benefits in terms of getting around more easily, sleeping better, improved mood and having fewer symptoms.

Once you have built up your basic level of activity, you need to think about keeping it at a good level – not just for a few months, but for the rest of your life! You can maintain your fitness by keeping going with your walking programme, your chair based exercises, or by doing other activities if you prefer. Depending on your own situation and the kind of activities that you enjoy, you may want to do other things, like joining an activity group, cycling or dancing.

The key question is: what activities can you do that you are likely to be able to keep doing on a regular basis? Keeping your basic fitness requires regular activity – if you stop doing activities your fitness will soon deteriorate. Have a look at the ideas for physical activity below and decide what you want to do to keep your fitness up. Most people find that it is easier to keep going with activities that they enjoy or that involve other people or that they can easily build into their usual routine (like using walking to get to work, taking the dog for a walk or joining a weekly activity group).

Remember to keep your fitness up you should be aiming for at least 60 to 150 minutes per week (depending on your starting level of fitness) of moderate intensity physical activity each week. So make sure that the activities you choose include this amount of time *working at a level that makes you breathe heavier, feel warmer and have a slightly faster heartbeat, but still allows you to talk.*

Feel free to use the planner to make a weekly goal and to track your progress and most of all enjoy the benefits that staying fit and active can bring – remember 'Movement is Medicine'!

Ideas for physical activity

- Keep on walking! This could be more enjoyable if it is shared with someone else?
- Try a few different activities until you find something you can stick with.
- Join an exercise group for people with heart failure or other heart problems – your

facilitator should be able to tell you what is available in your local area.

- Make walking part of your daily routine, such as how you get to work, or to the shops, or to make a regular visit to a friend or family.
- Dogs make great personal coaches as they always need walking! If you don't have a dog, do you have a friend or neighbour or family member who has a dog that would like a bit of extra walking?
- Join a club or start a regular social activity (for example bowls or darts or a singing group) that you can walk to and from. Doing things with other people can be a lot more fun!
- Do some other moderate intensity activity like cycling, swimming or dancing.
- Make it fun or make it social – what would you enjoy most?

Swimming

Swimming or other water based exercise (e.g. aqua aerobics) is enjoyed by many people and can be done safely as part of your programme. However, in some people, swimming or other water based exercise can put a higher burden on the heart than other forms of exercise, particularly if you have not done it for a while. If you would like to do these types of exercises please discuss this with your REACH-HF facilitator, GP, or heart failure specialist first.

The REACH chair based exercises

The chair based exercise videos that come with this manual are designed especially for people with heart failure. The videos contain a series of exercises (level 1 to 7) that use body weight to gradually increase the workload as you progress. Each level uses your own arm and leg weight to increase the amount of resistance you feel when carrying out each series of movements. This will make your muscles work more efficiently reducing the burden on your heart, so you will be able to do day-to-day things more easily. The exercises are organised into seven levels of increasing intensity – the lower levels can be achieved by most people but the higher levels are quite challenging. The initial levels are chair-based, but the more advanced levels require you to stand. The exercises are demonstrated in the videos. Each level of the programme includes a set of warm-up and cool-down exercises.

What you will need:

- comfortable clothing, including shoes or trainers, properly laced
- a robust chair, ideally one with arms (but a chair without arms will do)
- The REACH exercise videos

To access the chair based exercises online go to www.reachhf.co.uk

Password

Your facilitator may give you a different website address.

Step 1: Getting started

Your facilitator should help you to get started and you should discuss:

- Which level to start at. This should be recorded on your 'Exercise Record' in the Progress Tracker. At the start, your exercise goals will depend on your current fitness. A good indicator of this is how far you can walk in a certain amount of time or how long you can walk for without needing to rest.
- How to make sure that you are working at the right level of intensity. This is done through an assessment of your fitness using a walking test or through a series of questions by your facilitator about your daily activities. This information is used to prescribe a starting level for your exercise programme.

During the programme your facilitator will work with you to develop the skills to know when to progress or maintain the level of exercise. This will include using things like the talk-test, the 'Effort Scale' and importantly, acquiring an awareness of how you are feeling during and after exercise.

You should aim to do three exercise sessions each week. Ideally, you should spread the activity across the week, allowing a rest day in between each session.

Step 2: Building up your fitness

The intensity of exercise will be guided by the videos, which include prompts (both visual and audio) to help you assess your ability

to carry out exercise at this level. However, you should keep track of how much you are exerting yourself – Each level of exercise includes a warm up period which enables your heart muscle and the muscles in your legs and arms to get sufficient blood in readiness for the main exercise period. **The main exercise period should eventually make you breathe heavier, feel warmer and have a slightly faster heartbeat, but you should still be able to talk. This means you are working at a ‘moderate intensity’ – the level you need to be able to gain the most from exercise.**

Throughout the CBE level you will be prompted on the screen to consider how much effort these movements are requiring of you. Try to keep the effort to around 7 out of 10 using the Effort Scale.

You should stay at the same level until you feel ready to increase the level.

- *If you are struggling to complete the session or getting too exhausted, you may need to reduce the level you are on and build up from a lower starting point.*
- *If you found your last two or three sessions easy, you should start working on the next level (for instance you might progress from Level 3 to Level 4). As you move into level 4 and above of the chair based exercises, the movements, in the main part of each level, will start to introduce greater amounts of resistance particularly through your legs. This will make the exercise feel much harder compared to levels 2 to 3 and may make you experience higher*

rates of breathing. This is not a problem, but is something to be prepared for as you progress to these levels.

- Once accustomed to exercise some patients have enjoyed and benefited from using a combination of the chair based exercise and walking programmes. So, if you want to add some variety to your training, do talk with your facilitator about adding in either chair based exercises or walking to your exercise programme.
- **If you follow the chair based exercises for 10 to 12 weeks, you should achieve a basic level of fitness that is good for your heart and for your health in general.**
- You can build up your exercise routine further if you wish, or you can just maintain your fitness by keeping going at the level you have reached.
- At this point, you can also replace the exercise sessions with other ‘moderately intense’ activities if you prefer. If you do this, you should aim to replace each session with a similar amount of time of ‘moderately intense’ physical activity.

You can use the Progress Tracker to record what level you are working on and how easy or hard each session was. This will help you to see when it is time to increase the level.

Depending on your age and your overall health you may not be able to get to the higher levels of the chair based exercises. Don’t worry, that is perfectly normal. Any improvement from where you started means

that your fitness has increased and that is good for you – the aim is to build up your fitness as much as is reasonably possible. Once you have reached a level that is as good as it can be for you, then the important thing is to keep it up after your facilitator is no longer working with you!

If you are concerned that the amount of activity you are doing is too much, please discuss this with your facilitator or your GP.

Monitor your progress

It can be helpful to keep track of your progress as this allows both you and your facilitator to see how your fitness is improving over time. You can monitor your progress by ...

- the amount of effort you are making – how easy or hard you are finding it
- the amount of time you are exercising for

Your Progress Tracker allows you to record this and you may find it useful to discuss your progress with your facilitator each time you meet.

What to do if you get very out of breath

It is normal for your breathing to get faster when you exercise and indeed it is important for you to work at a level which does increase your rate of breathing. However, if you work too hard you may find that your breathing gets too fast and you start to feel increasingly breathless. If you get to the point of being so out of breath that you can't speak, this is a

sign that you are working too hard and should slow down.

If you start feeling that you are getting seriously out of breath and may be approaching the point where you can't speak, you could **try using the 'active recovery' technique below to manage your breathing**

...

- Monitor your breathing rate and slow down your activity as this will help you gain control of your breathing. Try to do this without stopping the exercise, but if your breathing doesn't settle, it is OK to stop!
- You should notice your breathing rate gradually slowing down and coming back to the right level.
- If this doesn't work then slow down further until your breathing comes back to a comfortable rate.
- The trick is to take action before you get so out of breath that you have to stop.

If at any point during exercise your breathlessness becomes distressing, then stop and concentrate on slowing your breathing to a normal rate. You can use the relaxation exercises later in this manual to help you to do this.

Helpful hints

1. Plan your week and fit the exercise time into your everyday routine.
2. It is good to challenge yourself, but don't overdo it, as this can make you exhausted

Your energy for the week is like having money in the bank. Don't spend it all at once or you'll go overdrawn!

the next day. Bear in mind what other work or household jobs you need to do and plan accordingly.

3. As a general rule, try not to do things that make you so breathless you can't speak. If you get to this point, you should probably slow down a bit.
4. If you wish, you can combine sessions from the chair based exercises and the walking programme. You first need to set a starting point for the new programme (discuss this with your facilitator). Then it is very straightforward – any session of walking can be switched for a session of the chair based exercises (and you can switch 2 or all 3 sessions if you like).
5. If you have chest pains when exercising and your GP does not already know about this, you should stop exercising immediately. Contact your GP as soon as possible to discuss this and your facilitator.
6. If you have nausea, dizziness or palpitations (feeling your heart beating abnormally fast or irregularly) when exercising, stop immediately. If these symptoms don't go away, contact your GP as soon as possible.
7. If you have been prescribed a GTN spray, always carry it with you, especially during exercise.
8. If you have run out of your usual medications, or have forgotten to take them, do not exercise until this has been sorted out.

If you have angina and you experience chest pain during exercise, stop exercising immediately. Take 1-2 puffs of your GTN (glycerine trinitrate) spray if that has been prescribed and wait for the pain to go away. Take a second dose after 5 minutes if you still have pain. Dial 999 if your pain is still not relieved after using your GTN spray twice, or if you experience unbearable chest pain at any time. If the pain goes away and you feel OK, you can carry on, but wait a few minutes and work within the limits of your angina.

9. Talk to your facilitator or GP if you have any concerns.

Step 3: Keeping going

Our chair based exercises are a great way to build up your strength through the body weight exercises. Hopefully, after a few months of regular exercise, you will be feeling the benefits in terms of getting around more easily, sleeping better, improved mood and having fewer symptoms.

Once you have built up your basic level of activity, you need to think about keeping it at a good level – not just for a few months, but for the rest of your life! You can maintain your fitness by keeping going with your walking programme, your chair based exercises, or by doing other activities if you prefer. Depending on your own situation and the kind of activities that you enjoy, you may want to do other things, like joining an activity group, cycling or dancing.

The key question is: what activities can you do that you are likely to be able to keep doing on a regular basis? Keeping your basic fitness requires regular activity – if you stop doing activities your fitness will soon deteriorate. Have a look at the ideas for physical activity below and decide what you want to do to keep your fitness up. Most people find that it is easier to keep going with activities that they enjoy or that involve other people or that they can easily build into their usual routine (like using walking to get to work, taking the dog for a walk or joining a weekly activity group).

Remember that, to keep your fitness up you should be aiming for at least 60 to 150 minutes per week (depending on your starting level of fitness) of ‘moderate intensity’ physical activity each week. So make sure that the activities you choose include this amount of time *working at a level that makes you breathe heavier, feel warmer and have a slightly faster heartbeat, but still allows you to talk.*

Feel free to use the Exercise Record in the Progress Tracker to make a weekly goal and to track your progress and most of all enjoy the benefits that staying fit and active can bring – remember ‘Movement is Medicine’!

Ideas for physical activity

- Try a few different activities until you find something you can stick with
- Join an exercise group for people with heart failure or other heart problems – your facilitator should be able to tell you what is available in your local area’.

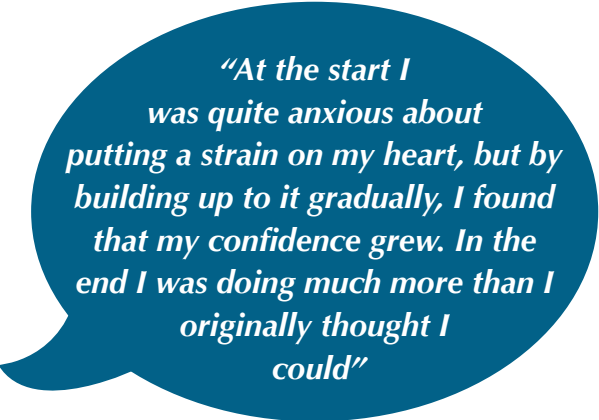
- Make walking part of your daily routine, such as how you get to work, or to the shops, or to make a regular visit to a friend or family.
- Dogs make great personal coaches as they always need walking! If you don’t have a dog, do you have a friend or neighbour or family member who has a dog that would like a bit of extra walking?
- Join a club or start a regular social activity (for example bowls or darts or a singing group) that you can *walk to and from*. Doing things with other people can be a good motivation!
- Do some other ‘moderate intensity’ activity like cycling, swimming or dancing.
- Make it fun or make it social – what would you enjoy most?

Swimming

Swimming or other water based exercise (e.g. aqua aerobics) is enjoyed by many people and can be done safely as part of your programme. However, in some people, swimming or other water based exercise can put a higher burden on the heart than other forms of exercise, particularly if you have not done it for a while. If you would like to do these types of exercises please discuss this with your REACH-HF facilitator, GP, or heart failure specialist first.

Problem-solving: Overcoming barriers to activity

Things don't always go according to plan – real life often gets in the way! If you find it hard to get as much exercise as you would like, it can be useful to think about what is making it difficult and how to overcome any barriers and what you can do to overcome them. Most people encounter some challenges when trying to change any aspect of their lifestyle – this is normal. However, the key to success is to figure out what the problem is and how to overcome it – it's all about learning from experience or 'trial and error'. If you keep trying and adapting your plan, eventually you will find the best way of staying fit that works for you and fits best with your situation. We have provided a list of ideas in the table below for overcoming common problems.



“At the start I was quite anxious about putting a strain on my heart, but by building up to it gradually, I found that my confidence grew. In the end I was doing much more than I originally thought I could”

The problem is...	Possible ideas...
“I can’t find the time”	If you are busy, try breaking the problem into smaller chunks. Try thinking of ways to build in a 10-minute block of activity into each day (or a number of days in the week). If you can do that, then try finding space for another 10-minute block. Planning ahead can be useful here – think about a typical day – how do you get from one place to another – perhaps walking could be part of your journey? Another possible solution is ‘multi-tasking’: How much time do you spend watching television? Do you need to be sitting down whilst doing this, or could you sometimes be doing some exercises at the same time? One good thing with the chair based exercises is that, once you have got the hang of them, you can do them without watching the videos. So you could do them whilst watching TV or listening to the radio.
“I am worried about going outdoors on my own”	It might help to go with a companion or to take a mobile phone with you. Make sure that somebody knows you are out walking and is available to call if you get into trouble. You can also choose a circuit for your walk, where there is always a bench or other place to sit close by. Choose a route where there are people around, or where it is easy to get home from. Build your outdoor time gradually – little by little.
“I have arthritis or other joint pain which stops me from exercising”	Joint pain can be a real problem, but research shows that doing more physical activity actually reduces joint pain in the long run. To get more activity despite having joint pain ... • Break it up into chunks – little and often. Build it up slowly. Once you get started the pain should decrease over time. • Try to find activities that don’t strain the affected joints or have low impact. If you struggle with walking, why not try our chair-based exercises as a starting point? A regular exercise programme is possible for most people, but you might need some more advice on how to get started. Your facilitator will be able to advise you further.

“My family thinks I should ‘take it easy’ and not exercise because it will strain my heart”	Explain to them how beneficial and safe regular exercise is for you and encourage them to join in with the exercise sessions – it will probably do them good too! See earlier, on the first page of this ‘Keeping Active’ section, for information about safety of exercising and how physical activity affects your heart.
“I am exhausted the next day”	It’s not uncommon to feel tired the day after an exercise session, especially if you haven’t exercised in a while. However, if you are exhausted you may be pushing yourself too hard/too soon. Remember that you need to build up slowly and progress gradually. It can be tricky to get the balance right, but it may be worth setting an easier target. Try to build up your fitness more slowly from a lower starting point. Your facilitator may be able to help you with this. Exhaustion may also be due to all the other things you have to do such as housework, gardening, shopping, hobbies, busy/stressful family life, work. Try to balance these activities with your exercise and plan how all these activities can be spread throughout the week.
“I have diabetes and it might affect my blood sugar”	Physical activity can reduce your blood sugar and regular exercise should be part of your treatment plan. However, you don’t want to lower your blood sugar too much or you may feel ill (this is often called ‘having a hypo’). To reduce the risk of a hypo 1) Follow a regular routine for eating, taking medicines and taking exercise. 2) Avoid working at more than a moderate intensity unless you are confident about how to manage this. 3) If you use insulin, you may need to adjust your dose to account for planned exercise. Talk to your doctor or facilitator about this. 4) Exercise with someone who knows what to do if you have a hypo. 5) Take a fast-acting carbohydrate snack with you to eat if you start to feel dizzy (e.g. glucose tablets). 6) Check your blood sugar before you go out and if it is low, have a carbohydrate snack. It may also be worth checking after your work-out. Remember: Blood sugar can be lower after exercise for a few hours. 7) If you do have a hypo, discuss with your doctor about how to avoid this happening.

“I don’t enjoy the exercise – it’s boring”	Would it be more enjoyable if you had some company? Why not invite a friend or partner or family member to join you. Could you vary where you do your activity? Maybe go for a walk in your local country or town park. Once you have built up your basic fitness, think about what alternative activities might be more interesting or enjoyable for you. You can replace your walking time or time spent doing the chair based exercises with any activity that is of ‘moderate intensity’ (as described above). Some exercises you can also do whilst watching your favourite TV programme (like our chair based exercises or walking on the spot). Background music or an audio book can also help to pass the time while you are walking (with headphones) or doing your home-based exercises. Even if you still find it a bit boring, weigh this up against all the benefits (at the start of this section). Maybe on balance it’s still worth doing?
“I have no energy to exercise”	Without doing some exercise you will have no energy – it’s a vicious cycle. If you start at the right level and progress slowly, your energy levels will increase over time as you become fitter. Try exercising at a time of the day when you feel you have more energy... for instance, some people find they are more exhausted in the late afternoon...so maybe exercising earlier in the day would be a better option? If you have a bad day with very low energy or through being ill, it is OK to miss a session – indeed you should aim to pace yourself and conserve energy on these days. If you are having mostly bad days in most weeks, then you should discuss this with your facilitator or your GP. If you are ill for several days, it may be best to rest or cut back on your exercise. When you feel better, gradually return to your exercise plan – you may need to set your target at a lower level and build back up from there. Also, make sure that you are taking your medicines appropriately and that your fluids are well-balanced (see the ‘Managing Your Fluid Balance’ section later on). Having fluid build-up or other heart failure symptoms can also drain your energy.

“I find it difficult to motivate myself”	It can sometimes be difficult to get going. Try thinking about the benefits of increasing your fitness – what would it mean for you if you had more energy overall, could sleep better and had fewer symptoms like breathlessness? This is what you can gain from increasing and maintaining your basic fitness. On the other hand, it might be cold outside or the activity might be boring or hard work. So, on balance, is it worth doing? Only you can answer this question. Other people (or kids, or animals) can also be good motivators, so is there anyone you can do the activities with or who you can talk with to help you get motivated?
“I’m too old to exercise”	You’re never too old to start exercising or to feel the benefits of exercising... you just need to start at the right level. Apart from the effect on your heart’s health, even a small increase in fitness can affect your mobility and your ability to do basic day-to-day tasks like getting out of a chair or doing the housework.
“I’m depressed and don’t feel like going out”	If you are feeling low, check the information about managing low mood in the ‘Keeping Your Spirits Up’ section later in the manual. Also, remember that exercise stimulates “feel-good” hormones. If you try a walk it will get you out of the house for some fresh air and a change of scenery and this can help lift your mood. If you really don’t want to go out, you can still do the chair based exercises in your home. If you can keep up some kind of physical activity, this can also help you to sleep better, which also improves your mood.
“I keep putting it off as other things in life are more important”	Your exercise sessions are very important to your health and quality of life. What will it take before you decide to make your own health a priority? Physical activity also helps you to sleep better so as time goes on, you should have more energy and be more mentally alert. Spending a bit of time on your fitness might help you to do more ‘other things’ rather than fewer.

“The weather is bad”

It's good to have a back-up plan for bad weather. How else could you get 10, 15 or 20 minutes of moderate intensity activity? For instance, this might include using the chair based exercises, going to a leisure centre or an exercise group.

If you want to be more active and are still stuck, you could discuss it with your facilitator. Friends or family members might also have some useful ideas.

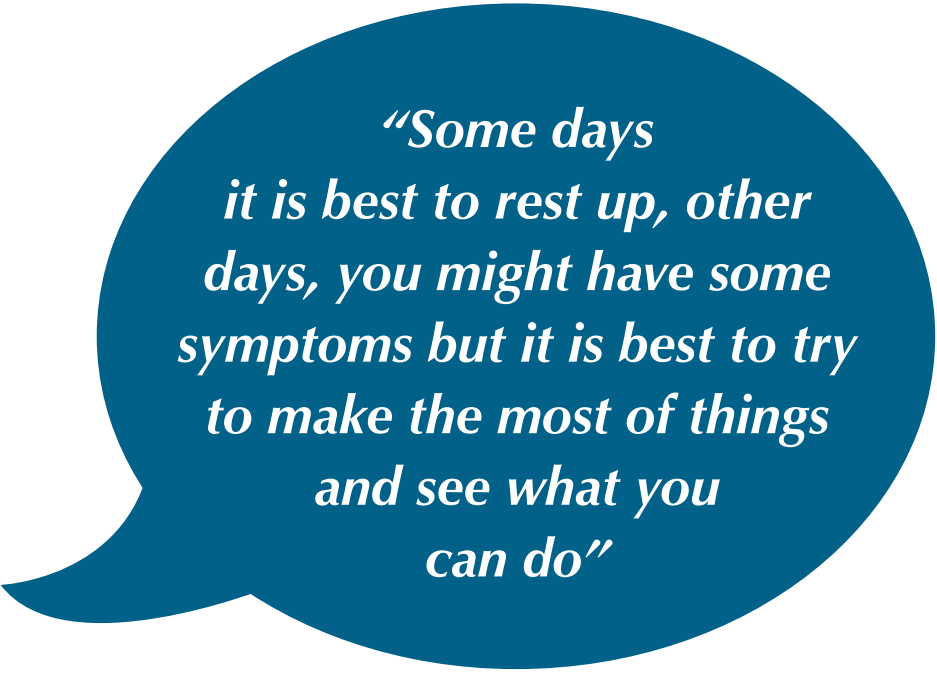
Setbacks and ‘re-starts’

Sometimes, if you have been ill or ‘out of action’ for a while, you may have lost some of your fitness and you may need to go back a few steps and work your way back up. This is normal and to be expected – your fitness will always increase or decrease, depending how much exercise you do.

If this happens, then it is absolutely fine to start the programme again from a level that is comfortable for you (you may wish to ask your doctor or facilitator if you have any concerns). This may be as little as 5 minutes per session to start with, but you should aim to build up your fitness over around 10 to 12 weeks.

If walking for 5 minutes is too difficult, then you could try the chair based exercises to start with – the lower levels of this programme are designed for people who cannot walk well.

If you have ‘good days’ and ‘bad days’ with your heart failure symptoms, don’t worry, this is normal – you have to be a bit flexible sometimes, but try to get your target amount of activity for the week by switching your activity days around. If you are having mostly bad days in most weeks, then you should discuss this with your facilitator, your GP or your heart failure nurse.



*“Some days
it is best to rest up, other
days, you might have some
symptoms but it is best to try
to make the most of things
and see what you
can do”*

Managing Your Fluid Balance

As we said in Part 1, when you have heart failure, this can cause fluids (water) and minerals (such as potassium, calcium and sodium) to build up in the body. This may be even more so the case if you have preserved ejection fraction. The build up of fluid in the body happens when the kidneys struggle to deal with having a reduced blood flow. The situation can be worsened by drinking too much fluid or forgetting to take your diuretic 'water tablets'. It can also be affected by how active or inactive you are.

If the fluid levels get too high this can be dangerous. Fluid can build up around the lungs, causing breathlessness and coughing and can put extra strain on the heart. On the other hand, being too dehydrated (having too little water) can also be dangerous. We require the correct amount of fluid and minerals to ensure the body works well – not too much and not too little.

When your fluids are building up too much, it is important to contact your GP, nurse, or facilitator for advice. You may need to:

- increase your diuretic medication – however, **make sure that your GP or heart failure specialist has approved of and is aware of any changes in your medication**
- restrict your fluid or salt intake – again you should only do this if advised to do so by a doctor or nurse
- in more severe cases you may need urgent hospital care – but if you take action early (as above), often this can be avoided

The key to keeping on top of the situation is to keep track of any changes in your fluid balance so that you can take early action. The following sections provide information on how to monitor for signs of fluid build-up, and what to do if this happens.

1. Checking for signs of fluids building up

There are various things you can do to check if your fluids are building up. These include checking for:

- a sizable increase in weight (+/- 2.3kg or 5lbs over 1 to 3 days)
- signs of swelling (for example in ankles or abdomen)
- an increase in shortness of breath or an increase in coughing or wheezing (such as becoming more breathless when lying down and requiring more pillows to relieve these symptoms)

Sudden changes in weight

Weighing yourself every day is a very easy way of monitoring your fluid balance. It is also the most accurate in telling you if your fluids are building up. Ideally, you should make it part of your daily routine, **even if there is no change over a long period of time – no change is a good thing!**

It is important that you weigh yourself in exactly the same way every day, to be able to detect a sizeable change in weight that is due to fluid rather than due to something you have eaten that day. Weighing yourself first thing

in the morning, before you have eaten, is the most accurate way of monitoring your weight to check for fluid retention. Even if you are unsure if your scales are completely accurate, using the same scales every day will still be able to guide you as to whether your weight has changed. If however you feel your scales are very unreliable, perhaps now would be a good time to invest in a new set. Remember you don't need anything fancy just a standard set of scales will do for most people. If you are concerned that you weigh much more than you should, have a chat with your facilitator, or GP, or your heart failure specialist for advice.

To help you get into a good routine we would encourage you to follow these 4 steps:

1. When you wake up in the morning go straight to the toilet and try to urinate to get rid of any removable fluid.
2. Stand on your scales and record your weight in the 'Checking for build up of fluid' section of your Progress Tracker.
3. Check against your weight over the past 1 to 3 days – how much has it gone up or down?
4. If your weight is going up, follow the advice in the 'Traffic Light Action Plan' at the back of your Progress Tracker.

Other tips - Weigh yourself in the same place, with the same type of clothing or without any clothes if you prefer, before you eat or drink, with the same scales, sticking to the same type of measurements either stones (st) and pounds (lbs) or kilograms (kg)

It is important to remember that you are not doing this to see how much you weigh, but to check if there are *sudden* changes in weight due to fluid build up.

What should I look out for? The general advice is to take action (with advice from your GP or nurse) if your weight increases by more than 5 pounds (2.3 kilograms) over a period of 1 to 3 days. It is important that you know the exact changes in your weight which require you to take action.

Swelling

Swelling is another sign that your body is retaining or holding on to fluid instead of getting rid of it when you go to the toilet to urinate. You may develop swollen feet if you sit for a long time for instance. Fluid tends to build up during the day, so it is most noticeable in the evening.

If you develop swelling and it doesn't improve with treatment, it is a sign that action needs to be taken. Checking for swelling is not as accurate as monitoring your weight every day, but can still be a useful method of monitoring your fluid balance. Recognising swelling is not always easy or accurate, but here are some tips.

Last thing in the evening when you are getting ready for bed, check for swelling of the feet, ankles, legs, abdomen and lower back. You can do this by gently pressing your feet and ankles, taking care not to damage your skin with your fingernails. Hold for 5 seconds and release. When you do this:

- is there an indentation or dip left in the skin?
- is it deeper than normal?
- does it take longer than normal to go away?

An alternative way of checking for swelling is to check whether your footwear feels tighter or whether your socks are leaving more of a mark than usual.

Remember to check both legs.

If you tend to develop swelling around your lower back, follow the same steps as above by gently pressing your lower back and noting down any changes. This may be awkward. Try not to strain yourself by twisting around. Get someone to check for you if you can.

Swelling of the abdomen can be difficult to see, so some people like to measure their waist. To be able to tell if your waist measurement is changing you need to be able to measure the same place each time. Your facilitator can also give advice as how to do this. Changes in how tight your clothes are (e.g., trousers, skirt, bra), or how they fit, can also be a good way to notice swelling.

Shortness of breath, cough and wheeze

Another way of checking for fluid build up is to be aware of changes in breathlessness, coughing or wheezing. Monitoring breathlessness is relatively simple, but it is important to specifically look for changes from your usual situation.

The first step is to be aware of what your “normal” is. Ask yourself “what situations do I tend to get breathless in?”

Do you normally get breathless when:

Yes

- ☐ You are exerting yourself more than normal?
- ☐ You are doing your normal activities?
- ☐ You are doing fewer than normal activities?
- ☐ You do any activity at all?
- ☐ You are resting?

The lower down you are on the list above, the worse your breathlessness is. You can recognise changes in your breathlessness when you are moving up or down on that list from where you would normally be. You can also keep track of how long it takes for your breathlessness to settle down when you stop doing an activity that makes you breathless. If this starts taking longer and longer, then your breathlessness is increasing.

Remember to also think about any changes in your sleeping pattern which may have been caused by your breathlessness. This may include the need to sit up or get out of bed during the night due to shortness of breath, or the need to prop yourself up with more pillows to help you sleep. So another way of monitoring breathlessness as a way of checking for fluid build up, would be to take note of changes in your sleeping pattern.

Finally, you could ask yourself: have I developed a new cough or wheeze, or is my cough or wheeze getting worse?

If your cough is 'productive', which means that you are coughing up phlegm (spit), you need to report this to your doctor or nurse if:

- the amount of phlegm is more than normal
- it has blood in it (red or pink), or

- if there is any sign of infection (a high temperature and/or yellow/green phlegm)

You can keep track of all the possible signs and symptoms of fluid build-up in the 'Checking for build up of fluid' section of your Progress Tracker. It can also help your care team to see whether your dose of diuretic medication needs to change.

Example:

	M	T	W	T	F	S	S
Weight today	70kg	71kg	73kg				
Weight gain	0	1	2				
2.3kg or 5lbs? over 1-3 days			✓				
More breathless							
More swelling			✓				

2. What to do if your fluids are building up

There are several ways to get your fluids back into balance, as we mentioned above. These can range from changing the dose of your diuretic medication to seeking hospital care.

Use the Traffic Light Action Plan to guide you

The 'Traffic Light Action Plan' at the back

of your Progress Tracker tells you how to recognise when to take action if your fluids might be building up, or if other important symptoms occur. Depending on your symptoms, you will be in either the 'Green Zone', the 'Amber Zone' or the 'Red Zone'. The actions you should take depend on which zone you are in:

- **Green Zone** – when you have a normal day (for you), this reminds you of your usual self-care activities

- **Amber Zone** – this describes the early actions which you should take when your signs and symptoms start to get worse

- **Red Zone** – this describes the signs and symptoms which require urgent action and what action you should take

Managing your fluid intake (if you have been advised to do so)

Sometimes, your nurse or GP or heart failure specialist may advise you not to consume more than a certain amount of fluid each day (usually 1.5 litres to 2 litres). **You should only do this IF a health professional has asked you to restrict your fluid intake.** You might also be asked to keep track of the amount of fluid you have over 1 or 2 days, just to check the amount you are taking in.

- Remember fluid is not only in all types of liquid you drink but also in the food that you eat. Foods high in fluid include: soup, ice cream, sorbet, gravy and jelly. Check the labels to find out the volume of fluid contained.
- Check the amount of fluid that can be held in your normal cups, mugs, glasses and bowls. Note this down in your fluid record.

ACTION

Discuss the ways you can monitor your fluid balance and the specific actions you should take if your fluids build up with your facilitator. Write the emergency telephone numbers for your local area on your Traffic Light Action Plan in case you need them in the future.

ACTION

Write down the amount you have been advised to limit your fluid intake to on the special 'Fluid Record' later in Part 3 of this manual. Use the Fluid Record to note down the amounts of all the fluids you consume in one day. At the end of the day, add the amounts together to give you a total.

- If you are worried about taking more fluid than you should fill a container with the amount of fluid you can have each day (such as 1.5 or 2 litres). Each time you have a cup of tea etc., pour out and dispose of the same amount of fluid from the container. When your container is empty you have reached your limit.
- If you have been asked to restrict your fluid intake, try to overcome thirst by sucking a boiled sweet or ice cube or chewing some chewing gum. Even swirling a small

amount of mouthwash, juice or water around your mouth can help reduce thirst.

Managing your salt intake

If you are struggling to manage your fluid balance, it might also be worth looking at the amount of salt you eat. This is because salt is directly linked to the amount of fluid you store. The more sodium in your body the more fluid it holds. There is information on how to manage the amount of salt you eat in the Healthy Eating section later in the manual.

Avoid getting dehydrated

It is also important to avoid taking too *little* fluid. This can cause dehydration particularly when you are: taking diuretics (water tablets) which make you urinate more, are in a hot environment, or if you have a stomach bug which causes vomiting or diarrhoea. Dehydration can cause tiredness and dizziness and can upset the mineral balance in the blood, all of which can make your symptoms feel worse. So, you should aim to keep a healthy balance – not too wet and not too dry!

“My weight increased over the last three days by 3 pounds, which put me in the yellow box on my Traffic Light Plan. I called my heart failure nurse – she advised that this may be because of eating too much salt and fluid, which made sense due to a bit of over-indulgence on crisps and such when my friends visited yesterday. She advised me to cut back on the salt and call again if my weight goes up again tomorrow”

Managing Stress

What is stress?

Stress is a natural reaction we experience to help us cope with challenging situations in daily life. In fact, we all need a certain amount of stress to enjoy life to the full.

However, stress can be a problem when we feel that life's demands are greater than our ability to cope with them. Sometimes we feel we cannot cope, either because we think these pressures are too great or that they never seem to end. Being diagnosed and living with a long-term condition like heart failure can be particularly stressful, especially if your symptoms are causing discomfort or your life has changed because of the condition. As a result, you may be feeling uncertainty, fear or worry. This is sometimes described as anxiety. Being anxious may, in turn, make symptoms like shortness of breath worse, making you worry even further.

The good news is that it is possible to manage or reduce stress in a number of ways. Many people have found that actively managing their stress levels also helps them to cope with the symptoms of heart failure. This manual and your facilitator will show you practical steps that you can take to become less stressed, despite the considerable challenges you may be facing.

When we are stressed or anxious our bodies produce adrenaline. Adrenaline produces a state of alert and gives us the extra drive to cope with challenges.



The stress thermometer

The stress thermometer shows how the rise in adrenaline affects the way we feel, from a state of deep relaxation to feeling excited. If the levels of adrenaline rise too high we may experience stress or anxiety.

What are the symptoms of stress and anxiety?

Fear is the main **emotional** symptom of anxiety. Stress and anxiety can also trigger **physical** symptoms including:

- dry mouth
- headache
- tense, sore muscles
- difficulty sleeping
- feeling tired
- indigestion
- 'butterflies' in the stomach

Anxiety can also affect your thoughts and attention, for example:

- loss of confidence
- lack of concentration
- difficulty making decisions
- racing thoughts
- difficulty with remembering
- Hostile or angry thoughts

Anxiety can also affect what you do, including:

- restlessness
- losing your temper
- increasing the amount of alcohol you drink
- increased the amount you smoke
- stopping you from meeting up with friends and family or even going outside
- being less physically active

When is stress or anxiety a problem?

A little stress or worry is not a problem. BUT if you find you are feeling stressed or anxious a lot of the time and it is getting in the way of your daily life then it may be worth taking action to reduce your stress levels.

Stress can also increase feelings of hostility and anger. This can lead to blaming others and strained relationships.



What can I do about it?

The stress management programme in the Heart Failure Manual is designed to help you recognise, reduce and manage your stress, anxiety, anger or frustration. You will be guided through this process by your facilitator.

How can I tell if I am stressed?

Fill in the checklist below to see how many signs of stress and anxiety you have. It is possible that you have been feeling like this for a while but have not recognised it.

Stress and anxiety checklist

Do these describe you at all?	
☐	Always rushing
☐	Impatient with others
☐	Keyed up
☐	Often losing your temper
☐	No time for chatting
☐	Critical of others
☐	Often changing your mind at last moment
☐	Feeling fidgety
☐	Can't make decisions easily
☐	Often tired
☐	Sigh a lot
☐	Quite forgetful
☐	Not often relaxed and peaceful
☐	Too busy for hobbies
☐	Often frowning
☐	Often worried
☐	Working till you are exhausted
☐	Life is not much fun any more
☐	Feeling frustrated

If you have ticked many of the boxes you may find the following pages on stress management helpful. The guidance and tools will be useful for yourself and also your partner and family.

Coping with stress and anxiety

You do not need to be stressed or anxious in order to benefit from the relaxation and stress-busting activities we suggest here. These are skills that everybody can benefit from, so feel free to share these with your friends and family. Not all activities suit everyone, but if you pick one or two and keep practising on a regular basis you should notice the benefits quite quickly. Most people find that using the relaxation techniques reduces their stress levels, helps them to sleep, gives them more mental energy to cope with any problems that arise and helps them to feel much more in control of things. Also, the more these activities become part of your daily life, the easier they become.

Relaxation techniques

The relaxation methods used in this Heart Failure Manual are a mixture of deep relaxation techniques which help you to let go of tension in the mind and body. It is not the same as sitting back to watch TV or having a cup of tea. You can learn these techniques by listening to and following the relaxation audio and practising the exercises regularly. Deep relaxation takes practice but you will feel the physical and mental benefits of this very quickly and these will continue if you keep it

**“I’m
glad I kept practising
when I look back at the
progress I have
made”**

up. Relaxation is an important part of stress management and can help you cope with problems and feel more in control of your condition. It has also been known to reduce pain, help with sleep and lower the heart rate (putting less strain on your heart). It helps to practise these techniques when there is no particular need for them, so you are ready to use them when you need them in future.

How long does it take?

To start with, we recommend that you practise by following one of the relaxation audio exercises for 20 minutes once or twice a day. The aim is to get you to a stage where you can use the skill at any time and get the same feeling of relaxation in a much shorter time, as and when you need it. Once you have learned how to do it, you will no longer need to use relaxation audio. It takes regular practice to develop this skill, but it is worth it!

Instructions for using the relaxation audio exercises

Make sure that no one will interrupt you.

Sit or lie down somewhere comfortable.

If you are using a chair it must be big enough to support your whole body when you are completely floppy.

The idea is to be able to let every last bit of tension out of your muscles. If you would not feel safe falling asleep in the chair, then it is not providing enough support. For instance, if you have to keep your arm balanced on the arm of the chair, you will still be using your

muscles to keep your arm there, and they won’t be completely relaxed. If this happens, maybe try resting your hands on your lap. It may help to put a thin pillow or cushion behind your neck for your head to rest on. The main thing is that you should be completely comfortable when relaxed. If you are not comfortable, try relaxing somewhere else – perhaps on the sofa or bed.

Points to remember:

- If your mind wanders, it doesn’t matter.
- Don’t worry or get annoyed if you feel you have missed a bit. Just start listening again and carry on.
- Remember – relaxation takes time to learn. It can’t be forced.
- You can’t make it happen by trying hard. Trying hard is the opposite of being relaxed.
- It doesn’t always work. How relaxed you feel after listening to the relaxation audio can depend on how you felt at the beginning.

But don’t give up. Remember that it has been proven that relaxation can help people manage their heart condition, including symptoms such as breathlessness and angina.

Ready to start?

Try using the relaxation audio exercises now.

To access the relaxation audio online go to www.heartmanual.scot.nhs.uk/heartfailure.

Your facilitator may give you a different website address.

Continuing relaxation

If you listened to the instructions on the relaxation audio you will have heard about two different ways of relaxation. Please go on listening to the audio once a day using whichever method you find best. If you like them both, listen to them both. Once you have got used to it, you can stop using the audio and just use the relaxation techniques whenever you need them.

The relaxation course also includes several other ways of relaxing that you may find useful. You may want to work through them in your own time.

Two reasons for learning relaxation:

1. To help you manage your condition by lowering your stress levels. If you keep listening to the relaxation audio twice a day this will happen automatically.
2. To control stress when stressful situations occur in real life.

The rapid relaxation exercises are some of the ways that you can do this. It is important to learn to do them without the audio. Then you will be able to use them whenever you want – at home, at work, on a bus or in the doctor's surgery. Wherever you are and whenever you feel tense, angry or frustrated you will be able to control your adrenaline level.

Try it now

- Can you relax your shoulders a little more?
- Let them slump down.
- Let the lines smooth out in your forehead, and relax your jaw.
- Can you relax your arms and your hands a little more?
- Let your hands spread open and relaxed.
- If you go through all your muscles as it describes on the relaxation audio you should find plenty of tension to get rid of.

Try to do this each time you look at your watch, or look out of the window.

You could add a small stick-on note on your fridge to remind you.

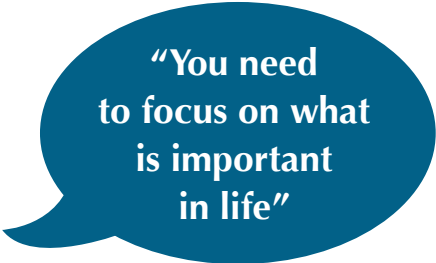
If you notice feelings of anger and frustration, do it then. Once you are relaxed, think:

- Is it really worth getting anxious, cross or upset about?
- If it is, then go ahead, but you will probably find that a lot of the time it isn't, and that it was just tension inside you that made it seem so bad, or annoying, or so important.

The other thing that is important is to avoid carrying muscle tension around with you. We usually don't notice this. It's only when you check your body that you notice the tension. If you check as often as possible during the day you will find that you become a more relaxed person.

Sometimes people who are learning relaxation find it difficult to get started. It can be hard to find the time or to concentrate. It is important not to give up. Discuss your feelings with your facilitator, who may be able to help.

Relaxation is good for everyone. It is good for both the body and the mind.



**"You need
to focus on what
is important
in life"**

Mindfulness – Focus on the 'here and now'

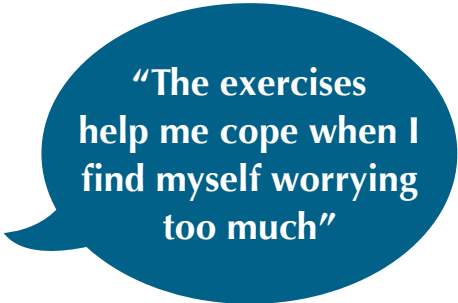
Mindfulness is another way of coping with stress, anxiety or anger and is the skill of being aware of and paying attention to the present moment. It is about being in tune with ourselves and others and our surroundings. When we pay attention to what is happening in the present moment we avoid constantly worrying about things that have happened in the past and what will happen in the future.

High quality research has shown that using mindfulness techniques can help people to relax and to overcome anxiety, depression and stress. It is therefore increasingly popular among people with long-term conditions like heart failure.

Mindfulness encourages us to accept ourselves as we are and to avoid judging ourselves and others. Similarly, it is also about accepting our experiences whether they are pleasant or not. This means resisting the urge to try and change things or to avoid thinking about problems. By being aware of negative emotions as they happen and how we react (often in unhelpful ways) we can learn to respond 'mindfully' instead. For example, if we have an unpleasant experience of pain, we may react with fear and anxiety and try to push the sensations away. Mindfulness encourages us to embrace whatever we are feeling and to know it is OK to feel the way we do. Often by doing this, the unpleasant experience passes more quickly and we find alternative ways of dealing with problems.

Mindfulness is an ancient skill based on meditation techniques that have been used for many hundreds of years, but it still seems highly relevant to the way we live now. We have all experienced the sense of being engaged with an activity that we really enjoy, sitting in the sun at a café, dancing, reading a good book, or watching a lovely sunset. This is being mindful or 'in the moment' – it is not an experience that is completely new to us. The skill is to avoid being distracted by other

thoughts about what happened yesterday and what will happen tomorrow which can spoil our enjoyment of the moment. Mindfulness is particularly useful in dealing with difficulties with health and daily living.



“The exercises help me cope when I find myself worrying too much”

Skills

Here are some mindfulness exercises. We suggest you try and practise one of these on a regular basis whether you are feeling calm or stressed. In addition, you could try the 3-minute breathing space exercise whenever you find yourself in a stressful situation.

Mindfulness approach to daily activities

Breathing space (3 minutes)

Back to the moment or *STOP* exercise (20 seconds)

Mindfulness approach to daily activities/Mindful eating

Mindful eating:

Eating is an activity we engage in a few times every day. But how often do you find yourself finishing a sandwich or a meal and not remembering what the food tasted like? Perhaps this was because you were caught up thinking/or worrying about something else or eating in a hurry. This exercise is an opportunity to increase our enjoyment of the food we eat. It can be very useful if we have a tendency to overeat – if you get more enjoyment out of less food, this can help to reduce the amount of food you feel that you need.

When eating just eat. When you are eating or drinking don't do anything else. Look at the colours, shapes, surface textures. Notice the smells and flavours in your mouth. Listen to the sounds of eating and drinking. Enjoy each bit, enjoy each moment.

If you like the sound of it, try this mindful eating exercise each day for a week and see how it feels.

"I find the short exercises simple but helpful. They do take a bit of practice though"

The 3-Minute Breathing Space

This is an exercise that we suggest you practise on a regular basis. You can use this technique whenever you feel you are stressed or running on automatic pilot. Think of it like a reset button or opportunity to step off the conveyor belt for a few minutes.

At various times of the day, see if it is possible to step out of automatic pilot for about 3 minutes. It can help if you set a reminder to do this.

The 3-Minute Breathing Space

1. What's here? (becoming aware)

Notice your posture. Straighten your spine and generally relax your body.

With your eyes open or shut, silently ask yourself:

What is my experience right now. ...in my thoughts ...and my bodily sensations

Allow and accept your experience even if it is unwanted.

2. Breathing

Gently guide your full attention to each 'in' breath and to each 'out' breath as they follow one after the other. Try noticing at the back of your mind Breathing in...breathing out or counting the breaths.

Do this for one or two minutes, using the breathing as a point of focus to bring you

into the present and help you tune in to a state of awareness and stillness.

3. Extend your awareness

Extend the focus on your breathing to your body as a whole, noticing your posture and your facial expression.

Recognise any sense of discomfort, tension or resistance. If these sensations are there, then guide your awareness to them by 'breathing into them' on the in breath. Then breathe out those sensations, letting them go with the out breath. If you can say to yourself on the out breath "It's ok whatever it is, it's ok". Let the sensations come and go. Don't try to hold on to them.

See if you can keep this sense of awareness throughout the day.

STOP

Use this short exercise to remind yourself to be aware of the present moment, bringing your mind back to the present without judgement or worry.



S = Stop

T = Take a breath

O = Observe

P = Proceed

Whilst you observe just try and be aware of your posture: how you may be standing, sitting or lying down. Be aware of the sensations of the body, what you see, hear, taste smell or touch. Practise a half smile while trying to relax your facial muscles. Then carry on with whatever you were doing.

You can do this at any time of the day. Try and find cues to do this: making a cup of tea

or coffee, standing in a queue, when you first wake up, whenever you feel angry or annoyed, when you lie down to go to sleep.

Managing demands and increasing the things you enjoy

Often, we find ourselves in a situation when the demands on us are too frequent or too great. We don't know where to start but this still doesn't stop us from constantly worrying about them. You may not be able to get rid of the demands, but there may be ways to help you reduce them and feel more in control and less stressed. Here are some suggestions and practical exercises. These come from research evidence and also directly from the reports of people with heart failure who have found these activities have worked for them.

"I set myself a reminder, it's amazing how I got so caught up with worrying about what has happened, or what might happen – the exercises get me back to enjoying the here and now"

Skills

Setting aside time to worry

It often helps to write down your worries and set aside a 'worry time' so that you are not constantly thinking about them. This is important because you may not be in a position to do anything about them

immediately. So you may as well not keep on thinking about them. For example, when you are in bed at night and worrying keeps you awake at night, write your worries down and tell yourself that you will look at the list and deal with them in the morning. This way you have made a decision and you may find that you will get to sleep easier.

Scheduling jobs/chores

Try this technique. Get a piece of paper and write three headings across the page.

Job	Deadline	Importance
A single word is usually enough.	This should be the absolute latest date by which the job must be done.	Score this out of 10 where 10 = most important and 1 = not all important.
Just as long as you know what it means.	If there isn't time, set one that you can manage easily.	If you can't find the time for all the things on your list, you should decide which ones to get rid of.

A common reason for having too much to do is taking on other people's problems and trying to solve them. Another reason is not being able to say 'no' to people or to 'work' (see Saying No later in this section).

You can check to see if you fall into this trap by using scheduling. Look at each deadline and write an 'M' for me beside each one that you set or an 'S' (someone else) if it was not you that set the deadline.

In this way you can see if you are setting yourself a lot of unachievable deadlines and if you are taking on work that you don't actually have to do.

For each 'M' deadline ask yourself 'Who got me into this', 'Should someone else be doing this?' and 'Am I trying to do the impossible?'

Job	Deadline	Importance
Buy birthday present for my wife	Next week	8 M
Fix car	As soon as possible	10 M
Tax return	Next month	10 S
Council tax rebate	Next month	10 S
Paint bedroom	As soon as possible	5 M
Weed garden	Couple of weeks	2 M

Scheduling is a way of gaining control when you are feeling under pressure from demands at home or at work.

- It helps us get an overall picture of what we have to do
- It helps us decide what needs to be done and what can be left until later
- It helps us relax when we feel more in control and know what we have to do

Saying NO

How good are you at saying NO? Some of these ideas might be helpful ...

‘No, I’d like to help but I just don’t have the time.’

‘No, I don’t know what you can do about that.’

‘No, I can’t come round just now.’

‘No, I’m going fishing ... for a walk ... to the pictures.’

‘No, I don’t work on Saturdays.’

Saying **NO** seems to be very hard for some people. They feel that they should always help other people out or be prepared to take something on whenever they get the chance. This is fine so long as it doesn’t lead to having too much to do and feeling under pressure all the time. **We have a duty to look after ourselves as well as other people.**

The best way to overcome the problem is simply to practise saying NO.

To start with you may find this very hard. You may feel quite guilty about not helping the person or not doing the job, but it is important for you to learn how to do this. If you refuse politely and explain that you are too busy, most people will accept it. If it is someone who you have always said yes to in the past,

they may be surprised and take some time to get used to it, but they will.

Set aside times when you do not work or will not be available (for example, “I have decided not to do any work after nine o’clock in the evening” or “Saturday morning is my book-reading time”). Stick to these protected times – however much piles up and whoever tries to persuade you against it. There are only so many hours in the day!

Choose other ways to relax that you may enjoy:

- playing with grandchildren
- playing a musical instrument or listening to music
- painting
- yoga
- t’ai Chi
- going for a walk

Often it is the enjoyable activities that we put off, but these are equally important, if not more important than the other activities we may have planned. Try and make a conscious decision about making space for some enjoyable activities in your life. Plan dates in your diary to do them – ideally plan at least one enjoyable thing each day.

Keeping up the UP things

One reason for stress can be that we have lost the balance between pleasure and work, or between pleasure and doing all our day-to-day chores.

Here is an exercise which can help to put this right. To do it you need a pencil and paper. Write all the good things in your life down one side of the sheet of paper – the **UP things**. Then write the worrying, unpleasant, adrenaline-raising things down the other side – **the DOWN things**.

Here are four ways to use your list to reduce stress:

- 1 Increase the amount of time that you spend doing the UP things.
- 2 Add new things to the UP side.
- 3 Reduce the number of things on the DOWN side.
- 4 Plan UP things for the future.

UP Things Enjoyable and relaxing activities	DOWN side Unpleasant, stressful activities
Painting Taking grandchildren out Relaxation Chatting with wife TV Seeing old friends Walking dog	Signing on Fixing car Money Arguing with the kids Gardening

This is how Jim McClure used the UP exercise.

- 1 He increased the amount of time he spent on UP things. He decided to take his grandchildren out once a week instead of just occasionally.
- 2 He added new UP things. He took up fishing again. He started tying fishing flies.
- 3 He reduced the number of things on the DOWN side. Jim hated looking after his car. He didn't really need it much now, so he sold it and immediately felt less stressed. He also hated gardening. He decided with his wife that they would put the back garden down to grass and pave over the front.
- 4 He planned UP things for the future. He suggested saving for a holiday and his wife was amazed, as he'd always been 'too busy' to take proper holidays. They got some brochures, looked online and had a lot of fun choosing a holiday. Just thinking about it was enough to make Jim feel more relaxed.

Why not try this for yourself?

If you have any questions about these exercises and activities, please discuss these with your facilitator.

Use the 'Managing stress and anxiety' section on your Progress Tracker to note down what you do to manage your stress or anxiety and whether this works for you or not. Try out different strategies and techniques until you find out what works best for you.

Skills for managing acute stress or sudden anxiety

So far the exercises and activities we have

described are ones that we practise to prevent or stop stress or anxiety building up. There may be times however that you experience sudden waves of stress or anxiety that can be very unpleasant. If you have been practising the exercises you will find that you can use these at such times. However there are some further ideas below that you can use to help manage any sudden bouts of anxiety or stress.

As soon as you find yourself becoming anxious think about the statements below. These are called the 'Five Rules for Coping with Anxiety'.

Example

What did you do to help manage stress this week?	How many times did you do it?	How did it make you feel?
1. Stop exercise	Once every other day	Felt good and could fit into my lunch break easily

Five rules for coping with anxiety

1. The feelings I have are the effects of adrenaline
2. These feelings are not dangerous – just unpleasant
3. Notice what is happening in my body right now – not what I fear may happen
4. Remember that when I stop adding to my anxiety with worrying thoughts, it starts to fade by itself

5. Wait, and give the fear time to pass. Do not fight it or run away from it. Just accept it.

Doing the rapid relaxation techniques or mindfulness exercises that work for you will help the feelings to go more quickly.

It is important to practise the relaxation or mindfulness exercises on a regular basis so that if you are affected by an episode of acute stress or anxiety you are ready to cope with it.

Panic attacks

Sometimes when we are stressed or worried we get a build up of adrenaline in our body that leads to feelings of panic. A panic attack can happen when we least expect it and can be triggered by a worrying thought that tips our adrenaline into panic levels [see the stress thermometer at the start of this 'Managing Stress' section]. In a panic attack your thoughts race, your breathing and heart rate increase (these are also effects of the adrenaline).

You may feel butterflies in your stomach and feel cold and clammy. Panic attacks can be frightening but they are not dangerous and are usually over within 10 or 30 minutes once the body has run out of adrenaline. Try to think of the five rules for coping, these will help.

Speak to your facilitator or GP if you need further help in dealing with stress, anxiety or panic attacks. This is an important part of your overall well-being.